

No Genuine Copula in Japanese: a reanalysis of 'da' as a locative postposition plus a one-argument existential verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *da* and its non-contracted form *dearu*. Traditionally, it has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the separability between *de* and *aru* and the inseparability between NPs and *de* show that this interpretation is inadequate. In sentences such as *kare=wa gakusei dearu* 'he is a student', the noun phrase *gakusei* plus *de* behaves as a single constituent, while *de* and *aru* are separable. This suggests that *gakusei de* forms a postpositional phrase (PP) and that *dearu* should be reanalysed as the locative postposition *de* plus the one-argument existential verb *aru*.

Under this analysis, *kare=wa gakusei dearu* is syntactically an existence-assertive sentence consisting of the ONE-ARGUMENT core clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the ADJUNCT *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The non-deletability of the syntactic adjunct *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity, since *gakusei=de* functions as the focus of the sentence. The paper also accounts for the default negation pattern *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* (partial negation) instead of *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* (total negation), showing that the negator applies to the adjunct domain *gakusei=de* rather than to the existence of *kare* itself.

This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *da/dearu* constructions.

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1. Introduction — Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and inseparability between NPs and *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu* have traditionally been treated as a copula equivalent to *to be* in English, as in (1), where *dearu* can be replaced by *=da*, '=' indicating enclisis:

- (1) kare=wa gakusei dearu
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP
 'He is a student.'

However, this analysis faces a major limitation: it cannot account for the **high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***. For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus/additive particle — the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — *=mo* 'also', the sentence cannot take the form in (2):

- (2) *kare=wa gakusei =mo **dearu**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) also(ADD) COP
 'He is also a student.'

but must be as in (3):

- (3) kare=wa gakusei **de** =mo **aru**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? also(ADD) COP?
 'He is also a student.'

The particle *=mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*, as if it were an infix. Furthermore, in (4):

- (4) kare=wa gakusei **deari** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a professional.'

the first *deari* may reduce to *de* alone as in (5):

- (5) kare=wa gakusei **de** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a professional.'

These facts show that ***de* and *aru* are separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* always remain contiguous**, as in (6):

(6) Kare=*wa* gakusei de aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de mo aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de, kanozyo=*wa* syakaizin=*da*.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* is assumed to constitute a single inseparable constituent, as Dalla Chiesa (2015) notes: "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase (in the closest proximity to the verb²)", where the parenthetical remark is this paper's author's. This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =de**. In what follows, therefore, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*. This separation between *=de* and *aru* is compatible with Matsuoka's observation that "the copula *da* consists of the postposition *de* and the verb *aru*" (2019: 142).

2. NP + *=de* as a locative adjunct PP and the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In Japanese, PPs of the form "NP + *=de*" function generally as adjuncts. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is assumed to consist syntactically of a **mandatory structure** [*kare=wa aru*] and an **adjunct structure** [*gakusei=de*].

In *kare=wa aru*, the predicate *aru* — or, more precisely, its stem *ar-* — can thus be analysed as a **ONE-ARGUMENT verb**, taking only the NP *kare* as its argument. When the verb *aru* **functions as one-argument predicate**, it means '**to exist**' — though rather literary, as in *ware omou, yueni ware ari* 'I think, therefore I am' — and the sentence *kare=wa aru* can thus be interpreted as 'he exists', **asserting the existence** of *kare*. As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although **PPs headed by =de** can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is therefore **locative** — not a physical but a **conceptual location**.

² She argues that the ungrammaticality of **neko=de wagahai=ga aru* 'I am a cat' supports her claim that "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase in the closest proximity to the verb". However, the ungrammaticality of this sentence does not arise from word order, but rather from the fact that *wagahai*, while functioning as a topic, is not marked by *=wa*. Indeed, although slightly awkward, *neko=de wagahai=wa aru* is not ungrammatical, and expressions such as NP=*de* *watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as the referent denoted by the NP I want to exist' — e.g. *ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as a rational member of society I want to exist' — sound much more natural.

Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The entire structure *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is thus, syntactically, composed of **the mandatory ONE-ARGUMENT clause** [*kare wa aru*] 'he exists' and **the ADJUNCT** [*gakusei=de*] 'in the conceptual domain "student"'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and the location of his existence is the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'. Schematically, *A=wa B=de aru* can be represented as **E(A) $\wedge$ IN(A, B)**, where E(A) — E abbreviates EXIST — denotes the **assertion of existence** and IN(A, B) the **specification of the domain of existence**.

Thus, in place of the traditional **copula-based** analysis in (7) = (1):

- (7) *kare=wa gakusei dear-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP-PRES
 'He is a student.'

in this paper, a **one-argument-existential-verb-based** analysis is adopted, as in (8), where CONCEPT-LOC abbreviates 'conceptual-locative':

- (8) *kare=wa gakusei=de ar-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

3. The difference between *sore wa gakkō=DE ARu* and *sore wa gakkō=NI ARu*

In contrast to the construction *sore=wa gakkō=de aru* in (9), hypothesised as **existence-assertive** in Section 2:

- (9) *sore=wa gakkō=de ar-u*
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'It exists, and it is as a school.'

in genuine **locative** constructions as in (10) and (11), where PHYSIC-LOC abbreviates 'physical-locative':

- (10) *sore=wa gakkō=ni ar-u*
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'It is in the school.'

- (11) *kare=wa gakkō=ni i-ru*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school= PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'He is in the school.'

the **locative argument is obligatory and always marked by the postposition =ni, rather than =de**. The formal difference between (9) and (10) further supports the above analysis. The verb *aru* — more precisely, its stem *ar-* — when used as a **LOCATIVE verb**, is a **TWO-ARGUMENT predicate with the argument structure [location, theme]**, the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =ni], as in *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* with the stem *i-* is used instead as in (11), with the argument PP [NP + =ni] unchanged, as in *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school', whereas the ungrammatical sentence in (12) which employs the PP [NP + =de]:

- (12) *kare=wa gakkō=de i-ru*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school=LOC(ADJUNCT) ?-PRES
 ' ? '

is not semantically interpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* should be regarded **SYNTACTICALLY** — though **NOT PRAGMATICALLY OR INFORMATIONALLY**, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a **structurally self-contained existence-assertive clause** *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', **accompanied by the locative adjunct** *gakusei=de*, **which specifies the domain of existence**.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the mandatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or 'as a student', serves as a **presentational sentence** in which **the focus is domaind on the adjunct** *gakusei=de*.

Therefore, the **non-deletability of** *gakusei=de* **arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability** rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP A <i>ar-</i>] + [PP B= <i>de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	"A exists, and it is in the domain B"	Existence assertion + domain specification $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$
Information Structure	[A= <i>wa aru</i>] + [B= <i>de</i>]	Given + New (default)
Pragmatics	Focus on B= <i>de</i> (default)	Pragmatic obligatoriness and non-deletability of B= <i>de</i> due to focus

5. Shift of focus and foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*

In the construction *kare=wa gakusei=de aru*, which can be schematically represented as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, the existential component $E(A)$ — the lexical meaning 'to exist' inherent in the verbal stem *ar-* — is backgrounded as given information, while the domain-specifying component $IN(A, B)$ is foregrounded as the focus of the utterance. As a result, the meaning 'to exist' is rarely brought to the speaker's or hearer's awareness in ordinary predication contexts.

By contrast, in example (13), which takes the form A WANT [$E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$], the situation is different:

- (13) *watasi=wa ryōsikiteki-na syakaizin=de ari tai-0*
 I(SUBJ)=TOP rational member of society=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist want-PRES
 'I want to exist as a rational member of society.'

Here, what is at issue is 'one's mode of existence', that is, an orientation toward a particular manner of being. In such a context, $E(A)$ is **no longer backgrounded but instead becomes part of the focus** as well as $IN(A, B)$, and the lexical concept 'to exist' encoded in *ar-* emerges as perceptually salient. This pragmatic shift of focus, which foregrounds the existential meaning of *ar-*, supports empirically the validity of analysing **the semantic structure of A=*wa* B=*de aru* not as $BE(A, B)$ but as $EXIST(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$** .

6. Old Japanese forms

In Old Japanese, the modern *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* would correspond to *kare gakusei nari*, derived from *kare gakusei=ni ari*. Before the emergence of the postposition-suffix sequence

=*nite*, the postposition =*ni* could mark both arguments and adjuncts. Thus, *kare gakusei=ni ari* can be analysed as consisting of the one-argument core clause *kare ari* 'he exists' and the locative adjunct *gakusei=ni* 'in the conceptual domain denoted by *gakusei*', as indicated in (14), which is consistent with the present hypothesis:

- (14) *kare* *gakusei=ni* **ari-0**
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The subsequent development *kare gakusei=n-ari* → *kare gakusei=nite ari* → *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* reflects the diachronic split between =*ni*, used for arguments, and =*nite*, used for adjuncts. This may represent a shift from a linguistic stage in which =*ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which =*ni* and =*nite* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively — a possibility that requires further historical investigation.

7. Default partial negation and the scope of negation marked by the particle =*wa*

Negation in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* 'he exists, and it is as a student' in (15) = (8):

- (15) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* *ar-u*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

DEFAULTLY appears as the partial negation *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* 'he exists, but it is not as a student' — underlyingly, **kare=wa gakusei=de=wa ara-nai*, since in contemporary Standard Japanese the negative form of the verb *aru* is not the theoretically expected **ara-nai*, but obligatorily the suppletive verbal adjective *nai* — ai in (16):

- (16) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de=wa* (**ara*) **nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT)=SCOPE OF NEGATION exist NEG-PRES
 'He exists, but it is not as a student.'

rather than the total negation — unnatural for native speakers — *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* 'he does not exist as a student', underlyingly **kare=wa gakusei=de ara-nai*, as in (17):

- (17) *kare=wa gakusei=de (*ara) nai-0*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist NEG-PRES
 'He does not exist as a student.'

This is because the sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* does **not negate the existence of *kare* itself**, but rather **negates *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**, since in Japanese **the particle *=wa* can mark the scope of negation**, as in (16).

Schematically, the partial negation *A=wa B=de=wa nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de=wa ara-nai* — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, in line with Section 2, whereas the total negation *A=wa B=de nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de ara-nai* — can be represented as $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$, that is, $\neg E(A) \vee \neg IN(A, B)$. Although this condition is compatible with $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$ or $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, the first case is inconsistent given the semantic postulate $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$ — hence $\neg E(A) \Rightarrow \neg IN(A, B)$ — and the option $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B) = \neg E(A)$ — namely, the third case — is pragmatically infelicitous in topicalised clauses with *A=wa*, since *A=wa*, as a topic phrase, tends to presuppose the discourse-givenness or existence of A and there are dedicated Japanese forms for existential negation such as *A wa inai/nai*; therefore, in practice the interpretation converges on $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Hence the former pattern, which unambiguously denotes $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, is judged to be the more natural one.

If *=de aru* were a single copula, then *A=wa B=de aru* would denote $BE(A, B)$, and its negation would be plain predicate negation — namely, *A=wa B=de nai*, represented as $\neg BE(A, B)$, with no *=wa* after *=de*. **Empirically, nevertheless, *A=wa B=de nai* is felt to be infelicitous, whereas *A=wa B=de=wa nai* is preferred.** This obligatory *=wa* on *=de* is unexpected under the simple-copula analysis, but follows immediately if the clause decomposes as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ and the intended reading is the partial negation $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Furthermore, if *=de aru* were a single copular unit, partial negation with *=wa* would necessarily take the form **kare=wa gakusei=wa de nai*, as in (18):

- (18) **kare=wa gakusei=wa de nai-0*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED)=**SCOPE OF NEGATION** COP NEG-PRES
 'He is not a student, but something else.'

The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *=de* and *aru* and the adjunctive nature of *gakusei=de*.

8. The contracted form =da

In spoken language, the contracted form =da is often used instead of =de aru, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=da* 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **contracted form =da** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex =de aru**, as shown in (19):

- (19) *kare=wa* *gakusei=d* **a-0**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The historical change from =de aru to =da, possibly via =dea³, involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but only a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de a* → *da* 'from the, of the'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au*, or for *de* and *a* into *da* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* or *from the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for =de and aru to form a single lexical item.

The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: =de functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and the stem of aru as the existential verb itself. This is precisely why the following colloquial dialogue is possible:

Kare=tte gakusei=da yone? — *Iya, gakusei=tte yū=ka, gakusei=de=mo aru=tte kanzi kana.*

'He's a student, right?' — 'Well, if you can call him a student, I'd say he's *also* a student, kind of.'

In this dialogue, the interlocutor, recognising that the underlying structure of *gakusei=da* is *gakusei=de aru*, when asked to confirm that *kare*'s domain of existence can be identified as that of 'student', replies that his existence extends to other domains as well, expressed by the form *gakusei=de=mo aru*.

Returning to Section 1, *kare=wa gakusei=de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da* 'he (is) a student, and she is a professional' is thus, underlyingly, a compound sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de ari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=de aru*, in which the first predicate *ari* is deleted as recoverable, on the

³ Historically, the form =dea, which yielded the modern =da, can be attested in Azuchi–Momoyama-period materials: *bonnin yorimo giūzaini fuxōzuru cotodea* '(it) is a reason for imposing a heavier guilt (on him) than on an ordinary person' (Amakusa Edition of *Esopo no fabulas*, 1593, p.475, ll.10-11, in Text Data Sets for Research on the History of Japanese).

basis of the structural parallelism between the two coordinate clauses, as indicated in (20):

- (20) kare=wa gakusei=de (ari) kanozyo=wa syakaizin=d a-0
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=LOC(ADJT) (exist) she(SUBJ)=TOP professional=LOC(ADJT) exist-PRES
 'He (**exists**) as a student, she **exists** as a professional.'

Therefore, *=da* as a whole should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a **phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction *=de aru*** (more theoretically, *=de ar-0*, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix specified as [–past]).

9. Conclusion — *=da* not as a copula but as the conceptual-locative postposition *=de* followed by the one-argument existential verb *aru*

To summarise, the syntactic structure of *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' consists of a **mandatory existence-assertive clause** [*A=wa aru*] 'A exists' and an **adjunctive phrase** [*B=de*] 'in the conceptual domain denoted by B' or 'as B'. It should therefore be syntactically represented as *A=wa B=de aru*. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, composed of the existential verb *aru* and the postpositional phrase *B=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of A is realised. The more colloquial form *=da* is a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal *=de aru*.

Thus, through the above syntactic analysis, it has been possible to account, by means of a single, consistent principle — namely, the **assertion of existence by** [*NP₁=wa + ar-*] and the **specification of the domain of existence by** [*NP₂ + =de*], schematically represented by **E(NP₁)** $\wedge$ **IN(NP₁, NP₂)** — for:

- Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*
- Inseparability between NPs and *de*
- Optional omission of *aru* in *dearu*
- Foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*

- Historical development $A\ B=ni\ ari \rightarrow A\ B=nari \rightarrow A\ B=nite\ ari \rightarrow A=wa\ B=de\ aru$
- Ground on which the default negation of $A=wa\ B=de\ aru$ is not the total $A=wa\ B=de\ nai$ but the partial $A=wa\ B=de=wa\ nai$
- Underlying structure of $=da$ as $=de\ aru$

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